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Claude For Dummies

Your Complete Guide to Claude and Claude Code

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AI FOR THINKERS. CODE FOR BUILDERS.

Grok

Claude and Claude Code For Dummies

Your Complete Guide to Anthropic's AI Assistant and Coding Agent

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Contents

Introduction — Claude and Claude Code
Chapter 1 — Using Claude (Chat and Plans)
Chapter 2 — Getting Started with Claude Code
Chapter 3 — Working with the Coding Agent
Chapter 4 — Plan Mode, Cloud Sessions, and Projects
Chapter 5 — Models, Usage, and Limits
Chapter 6 — Best Practices and Safety
Appendix — Glossary and Resources

Introduction

Claude and Claude Code

Claude is Anthropic's AI assistant, available on the web, desktop, and mobile. It supports conversational work, analysis, writing, research, and file handling. Claude Code is the terminal-native coding agent that reads your repository, plans changes, edits files, runs commands, and iterates. Claude Code is included with paid Claude plans (Pro and above) or available via the API.

This guide covers both the general Claude experience and the specialized Claude Code agent. It is written for beginners and intermediate users who want a clear overview of how to get started, use the tools effectively, and understand plans and limits. Features and pricing evolve; always check official Anthropic documentation.

REMEMBER

Claude is the conversational assistant. Claude Code is the agent that works directly inside your codebase from the terminal. Both draw from the same underlying models and (on subscription plans) shared usage limits.

Chapter 1

Using Claude (Chat and Plans)

Access Claude at claude.ai or through the desktop and mobile apps. Free tier offers limited chat. Paid plans (Pro, Max, Team, Enterprise) unlock higher usage, Claude Code, Projects, and additional features such as Cowork or Design on certain tiers.

Main Plans

• **Free:** Chat only. No Claude Code.

• **Pro:** ~$20/month (lower annually). Includes Claude Code and higher limits.

• **Max:** $100 (5x) or $200 (20x) for substantially higher usage.

• **Team / Enterprise:** Per-seat options with admin controls; Enterprise often combines seat fees with API-rate usage.

> **TIP**
>
> Start with Pro if you want Claude Code. Free is useful for trying the chat interface only.

Chapter 2

Getting Started with Claude Code

Claude Code runs in your terminal. Install the CLI, authenticate with a paid Claude account or API key, navigate to a project directory, and start a session.

1. Ensure you have a Pro, Max, Team, or Enterprise plan (or an API key).

2. Install the Claude Code CLI following official instructions.

3. Authenticate.

4. Open a terminal in your project folder.

5. Start a session and describe a task.

6. Review proposed changes and diffs before accepting.

REMEMBER

The agent explores your repository, proposes plans or edits, and can run commands under your control. You remain responsible for reviewing outputs.

Chapter 3

Working with the Coding Agent

Describe tasks in plain language: implement a feature, fix a bug, write tests, refactor, or explain code. The agent reads relevant files, plans steps, makes edits, and can execute shell commands (tests, builds, etc.). It works in a loop, observing results and adjusting.

Use clear requests and provide context when helpful. An AGENTS.md or similar project file can document conventions. Always review diffs and test results. Use version control so changes are easy to revert.

> **TIP**
>
> For larger tasks, start in Plan Mode so you can review the approach before code is changed.

Chapter 4

Plan Mode, Cloud Sessions, and Projects

Plan Mode lets the agent outline steps without modifying code until you approve. Cloud sessions run Claude Code on remote infrastructure so work can continue while your local machine is offline; they use the same usage limits. Projects (relaunched with parallel agent support) allow coordinating multiple threads under a shared goal.

Additional features include subagents, permission modes (including Auto mode on some plans), and hooks. These evolve—consult the current documentation and CLI help.

Chapter 5

Models, Usage, and Limits

Claude models include Opus (highest capability), Sonnet (balanced), and Haiku (faster/lower cost), with version numbers that advance over time. Claude Code typically uses the models available on your plan or selected via API.

On subscription plans, usage is shared between chat and Claude Code. Limits are typically measured in a rolling five-hour session window plus a weekly cap. Higher plans provide larger allowances. API usage is billed per token. Monitor usage inside the CLI or dashboard.

WARNING

Heavy agent sessions consume usage quickly. After limits are reached you must wait for reset or use additional credits/API billing. Start with smaller tasks while learning.

Chapter 6

Best Practices and Safety

• Begin with small, non-critical tasks.

• Always review diffs and run tests before accepting changes.

• Use version control and commit frequently.

• Keep secrets out of the repository and prompts.

• Configure appropriate permission modes.

• Document project conventions for the agent.

• Monitor usage to stay within plan limits.

• Stay updated with official release notes.

Appendix

Glossary and Resources

Claude: Anthropic's conversational AI assistant available on web, desktop, and mobile.

Claude Code: The terminal-native coding agent that operates on your codebase.

Plan Mode: A mode in which the agent proposes steps before making code changes.

Cloud Session: A Claude Code session running on remote infrastructure.

Opus / Sonnet / Haiku: Model families ranging from highest capability to fastest/lowest cost.

Resources

• claude.ai (web interface)

• Anthropic official documentation and Claude Code guides

• CLI help and release notes

• Pricing and plan pages on anthropic.com or claude.com

About the Author

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This is an independent educational guide. Claude and Claude Code features, models, limits, and pricing change. Always consult official Anthropic documentation for the most current information.